

Open Source Powered Education

Open educational resources

In India, with two-third of the population unable to go to schools, it is important that people get free access to educational content. There is need for large-scale creation of open educational resources (OERs) on websites under a 'creative commons share alike' licence—a licence that allows users to download, modify and use content freely as long as it is not for commercial purposes. Instead of copyrighted materials and use of proprietary software to develop them, India can only afford FOSS (Free and Open Source Software) and OERs. The website 'Wikieducator' (WE) was started in May 2006 by Dr Wayne Mackintosh of the Commonwealth of Learning (COL), Canada, with the specific purpose of providing a site for uploading educational content under the creative commons licence. At present, it has over 9000 registered users worldwide, with about 300 from India. Wikieducators believe that "ideas want to be free" and that it is important to "freely share ideas and knowledge."



Dr Savithri Singh
principal-Acharya
Narendra Dev
College, Delhi
University,
evangelist &
member of the
first International
Advisory Board of
the WE

Flexible enough for diverse requirements

Most of the institutions put their best efforts, time and huge funds in acquiring the short-term technology solutions for immediate relief and might land up repeating the same mistake to manage the future requirements. These institutions of diverse academic activities normally procure the technology to make their so-called infrastructure richer rather than adopting it as per their institutional or curriculum requirements. Furthermore, these solutions are not flexible enough to cater to the needs of higher education. Technology solutions based on Open Source are available to make significant contribution in the institutions of plural academic and financial structure. 'Moodle' has been the most efficient Open Source solution by the learning communities worldwide. It is quite flexible and, by default, caters to the most of the requirements one can think of in the higher education domain.



Dr Sanjeev Singh
Institute of
Informatics &
Communication,
University of Delhi
South Campus

Collaborative sharing of information is possible

Collaborative sharing of information has been made possible by the latest Web technologies and philosophies like Open Source. Wikis and blogs are examples that strike instantly. Compared to the traditional encyclopedia in printed form, this is a far more effective medium as authentic, interesting piece of information, free of cost, can be uploaded and will be available to everyone in a relatively short span of time without waiting for the next edition.

Reputed institutes like MIT have Open Sourced their curriculum as OpenCourseWare. The day is not far off when we will have MIT graduates across remote villages in India who have never ventured out of even their districts!



Varad Gupta
director, Keen &
Able Computers

Costs can come down drastically

Introduction of Linux in school syllabi and freedom to choose a distro can drastically reduce the hardware maintenance and upgradation costs. This is because in Open Source environment, one does not require a P4-Core 2 Duo PC to teach wordprocessing and 'C' programming. Schools should opt for some FREE-community-driven distro rather than paid-support, subscription-based distro.



Limesh Parekh
CEO, Enjay
Network Solutions

Online Education Resource Management

Web-based Campus Management by Chalkpad

Chitkara University management wanted to build lasting student relationships through an integrated Web-based university campus management solution with the capability of automating the entire student life-cycle management processes including pre-admissions, admissions, academic delivery, examinations, award of degrees, student ID card printing and alumni interaction, and further integration of these processes with library, hostel and fleet management. It implemented ChalkPad's UnivPad as a complete Web-based campus management solution. Over a period of last one year of smooth operation, Chitkara University's management has analysed that out of 1100 students enrolled, all the staff members and 80 per cent of students accessed their UnivPad on a daily basis through the Internet. At any given point of time, someone in the university accessed UnivPad, and some students accessed it even on holidays. By implementing UnivPad, Chitkara University has experienced increased efficiencies and cost-savings all across the university, while simultaneously allowing faculty members and administrators to make more informed decisions.



Asheesh Bhatnagar
chief campus
evangelist,
Chalkpad
Technologies